HARSHA VEMULAPALLI

Design & Research Executive | Enterprise SaaS & Platforms
Metro Detroit, MI · hello@harshav.com · linkedin.com/in/hvem · harshav.com/for/enterprise

SUMMARY

Design executive with 25+ years — including 16+ years leading and scaling large design organizations with director-level reports — across B2B SaaS, enterprise, and regulated platforms. Currently lead a 70-person global UX, research, and content strategy organization at Siemens across seven countries. Hands-on in interaction design and visual craft, with a proven record building AI-native design practices — from agentic research tooling to AI-powered product experiences — and the quality systems (design system governance, definitions of done, launch review frameworks) that let distributed teams, of any size, ship at a consistently high bar. Player/coach leader who has taken design orgs through major inflection points — platform transformations, a Sub-to-SaaS pivot, post-COVID re-platforming — while building trusted, XFN partnerships with Product and Engineering.

SKILLS

AI-Native Design Leadership: Agentic UX & agentic reasoning · AI tooling adoption & workflow redesign · building org-wide AI fluency · LLM integration & prompt design · validation frameworks for LLM outputs · conversational UX design · AI-assisted creation & curation

Design Org Leadership & Scaling: Leading large, distributed design orgs (70+ people, director-level reports, 16+ years at this scale) · org design & succession · player/coach leadership · culture & mentoring · XFN leadership with Product & Engineering · exec-level stakeholder alignment · leading through inflection points

Interaction Design & Visual Craft: Interaction design · visual design · design critique & quality bar-setting · human-computer interaction · data visualization · behavioral science

Design Systems & Quality Frameworks: Design system ownership at enterprise scale (3,000+ creators / 100K+ pages / 150+ sites consolidated) · definitions of done · launch review frameworks · experience governance · workflow optimization

B2B SaaS Product & Research: B2B SaaS & multi-user platform design · enterprise workflow design · UX research & research operations · usability testing

Tools: Figma/Figma Make · Copilot · Notion · Miro · Jira · Dovetail · UserTesting · Adobe CC · Generative AI tools · Agile/Scrum

EXPERIENCE

Global Director, Experience Design & Research – Siemens – Detroit, MI January 2025 – Present

Lead the global UX, research, content strategy, and localization organization I grew from 5 to 70 people (about 58 employees plus embedded contractors) across seven countries — supporting a complex B2B software ecosystem and AI-driven customer experiences.

- Consolidated 150+ sites into one Siemens.com, rebuilt around the marketplace — unifying the marketing site, first- and third-party marketplaces, and business-unit selling channels into a single explorable catalog of hundreds of thousands of products — and govern the One Siemens design system serving 3,000+ creators across 100K+ pages.
- Set the org's AI agenda: led a Microsoft Copilot research agent over a unified research repository (−34% time-to-insight, +20% data utilization) and a persona agent grounded in 80 interviews and 800+ surveys, now in daily use by research and approved for the extended design team, with accuracy and hallucination evaluation gating wider rollout.
- Hold the quality bar at scale: no UI moves to development without an accessibility review, and built workflow automation that validates design-system compliance in design and brand, accessibility (WCAG 2.1), and content-strategy compliance in content authoring.
- Own the design of the purchase and finance funnel experience, partnering closely with Product and Engineering to ship platform-level improvements at enterprise scale.
- Own a $2M annual operating budget (excluding salaries) and report to the SVP of eCommerce; partner as a peer with VP and SVP business leaders on Xcelerator Marketplace growth, and with Product and Engineering on roadmap and tradeoffs.
- Grew 10+ designers into manager and director roles; built a career growth tool that combines industry best-practice frameworks with self- and manager-scoring, so team members at every level can find and develop the skills for the roles they aspire to.

Director of User Experience, Digital Industries Software – Siemens – Detroit, MI April 2023 – January 2025

Responsible for design, research, and content for Siemens Digital Industries Software's sites; led a 35-person organization (3 direct reports).

- Player/coach on an AI-powered product finder: cut scope to the customer's next step, drew the initial layout, validated with 5-second and data-driven tests, prototyped in Figma Make, and shipped in React on Contentful; +23% conversion and +28% engagement, measured in Amplitude.

Senior Director, User Experience Design & Research – VMware – Detroit, MI April 2021 – September 2022

Led design, research, and experience strategy through VMware's Sub-to-SaaS transformation — a company-level inflection point — while redesigning tools and services for a post-COVID hybrid workforce.

- Redesigned mission-critical CPQ quoting workflows for 35,000+ users, cutting time-on-task 30% and accelerating SaaS deal velocity.
- Shipped an experience scorecard used by thousands of employees; re-platformed hybrid-work systems while holding 75%+ CSAT and reducing support load 20%.
- Operated as player/coach: contributed directly to critical design work while mentoring senior ICs and scaling leadership capacity across a distributed team.

Senior Manager, UX Design, Amazon Smart Vehicles – Amazon – Detroit, MI September 2022 – January 2023

- Directed design and research for a multi-stakeholder vehicle platform with embedded commerce, media, and advertising; introduced leaner processes that cut timelines 12%.

Director, Digital Brand, UX and Research – CARFAX – Centreville, VA October 2019 – April 2021

- Led UX, graphic design, and research teams through an end-to-end product redesign, achieving a 7% conversion lift and a 26% reduction in dev churn.
- Established a repeatable design process and research cadence that improved brand consistency and customer retention.

Head of Design, North America – Robert Bosch, LLC – Detroit, MI October 2016 – October 2019

Joined as employee 0 and built Bosch's internal design consultancy from the ground up into a ~120-person practice (5 direct reports, 90 indirect).

- Ran an internal design agency and scaled a Design Thinking practice org-wide, building a design incubator that let non-design teams prototype and launch with startup-level agility — a hands-on model for embedding design fluency broadly across a large organization.
- Drove service design initiatives that saved $6M; led research and design for an AI/ML infotainment system that lowered hardware costs and glance times.

User Experience Manager – General Motors – Detroit, MI September 2014 – October 2016

- Built a pattern-driven global strategy that launched 7 mobile apps in 23 languages within one year across seven brands.
- Scaled and led a 140-person multidisciplinary team across research, UX, visual design, and front-end development in Detroit and Austin.
- Created an in-app services revenue stream exceeding $1M in its first year.

PRIOR EXPERIENCE

Design Manager, Air Mobility Command – Charleston, SC (May 2013 – September 2014)
User Experience and Analytics Manager, Centers for Disease Control and Prevention – Atlanta, GA (December 2010 – May 2013)
Interaction Designer, Blackbaud – Charleston, SC (Nov 2007 – December 2010)
Product Manager & Design Engineer, Morris Digitalworks – Augusta, GA (Feb 2004 – Oct 2007)

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Science – Information Technology, American InterContinental University

CERTIFICATIONS

Decision by Design (Farnam Street) · **Google AI Essentials** (Google) · **Behavioral Design** (Irrational Labs) · **UX Research** (University of Denver)

THOUGHT LEADERSHIP

"**Leading Teams through AI**", Panel Speaker — Research Guild, Dec 2025
"**IDC MarketScape: Digital B2B Ecosystems and Marketplaces**" — IDC, Sept 2025
"**Forrester: Leveraging AI for B2B E-commerce**" — Forrester, 2025